base from AAP as essential for a comeback in Delhi. Describing the 2024 Lok Sabha alliance with AAP as a major misstep, Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav says, "Had we avoided attempting coalition rule with AAP in 2013, our decline wouldn't have been this steep. The 2024 decision was an even bigger mistake, and we've paid the price." Congress leaders cite past experiences to justify their stance. "Senior leaders of our state units in Gujarat, Goa, Delhi and Punjab have strongly opposed any alliance with AAP. They have witnessed firsthand how the AAP indirectly aids the BJP," claims Ajay Maken, Congress treasurer and former Union minister.

THE MUSLIM-DALIT VOTE

Internally, the Congress faces both challenges and opportunities. A weak grassroots network and factionalism remain hurdles, but the party is focusing its strategy on consolidating Muslim and Dalit votes through candidate-centric campaigns in around 20 winnable constituencies. Muslims, who make up 12.9 per cent of Delhi's population, hold significant sway in seven constituencies and are a substantial force in 15 others. AAP's grassroots outreach and largely secular stance have historically resonated with the Muslim community. The party had secured all six seats in the 2020 assembly polls. Despite its subtle shifts towards soft Hindutva, 69 per cent of Muslims supported AAP in 2020, while the Congress secured only 15 per cent, according to the India Today-Axis My India exit poll at the time.

The Congress now highlights instances of AAP's soft Hindutva approach, such as Arvind Kejriwal's recitation of the Hanuman Chalisa and endorsement of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, as signs of ideological inconsistency. These actions, argues the Congress, have eroded minority trust in AAP. While some believe the Congress has a chance to regain Muslim support, political analysts believe that Muslim voters may strategically lean towards AAP if the BJP intensifies its campaign. "As the election date approaches, the minority community might perceive the Congress as a vote-splitter inadvertently aiding the BJP's agenda—a narrative the AAP is likely to amplify through WhatsApp groups," says political analyst Amitabh Tiwari.

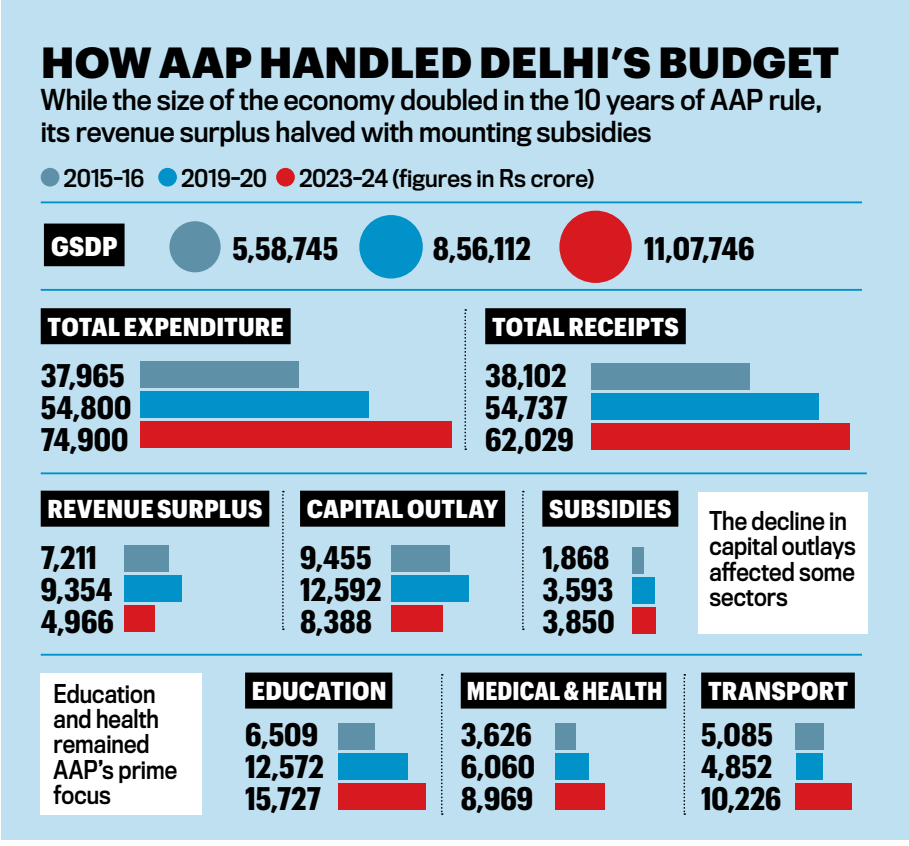
The Dalits, who comprise 16.7 per cent of Delhi's population, are a crucial electoral bloc. Historically loyal to the Congress, Dalit support has shifted to AAP in recent years due to welfare schemes like free power and water. AAP swept all the 12 SC-reserved constituencies in both 2015 and 2020, with the Congress's vote share plummeting to just 3.97 per cent in the latter. The Congress is now attempting to reclaim Dalit support by addressing grievances and promising tangible benefits such as increased representation and welfare programmes. Party leader Rahul Gandhi's focus on protecting the Constitution and social justice is meant to resonate with Dalit voters, by projecting the Congress as a defender of their rights.

THE BATTLE OVER MODELS

The Congress has structured its campaign around a pointed critique of AAP's governance, highlighting issues like the alleged corruption in the "Liquorgate" scandal and the erosion of public infrastructure. Rahul has used social media to draw attention to problems such as garbage accumulation in Delhi, mocking Kejriwal's claim of transforming the city into a "Paris". The "Sheesh Mahal" controversy, concerning Kejriwal's renovation of the chief ministerial residence, has become a cornerstone of the Congress attack. The party has rolled out a suite of welfare initiatives to address economic and social inequities in Delhi, positioning them as practical solutions to everyday challenges. As part of its outreach, the party plans to distribute guarantee cards across Delhi, a strategy that proved successful in Karnataka.

Kejriwal, though, remains the all-too-stable eye of the storm for both the BJP and the Congress. The AAP supremo dismisses talk of this being a battle for his political survival. Instead, he says Delhi voters are being asked to choose between two models of governance—the AAP one where state or national finances and resources get distributed equitably to the common man, especially the underprivileged, and the BJP model that favours arabpatis, or billionaires. That's a classic Kejriwal binary that has fetched him handsome electoral returns in the past. Whether it will carve out a future for him, the results on February 8 will tell. ■

–with Anilesh S. Mahajan and Kaushik Deka



Source: Revised Estimates, Delhi Budget Analysis, PRS Legislative Research